

Remembering the Tunnels

When I started school, each day during Outside Time I played with my twin brother, Linus, in the Tunnels, a forested area full of paths and nooks and crannies among honeysuckle, trees, and overgrown goldenrod. In the Tunnels was a community of students who built, claimed, and maintained “houses,” invented and performed games of dramatic play and make-believe, and started businesses where potions and pet rocks and real estate were sold or traded or otherwise bartered for wood gold and honeysuckle leaves and beech tree nuts and all manner of outdoor doohickies, which were the currencies of the Tunnels.

In this thriving society of invention, Linus and I befriended two middle school seniors named Haley and Kira. They were building a house in the skeleton of a fallen tree. Linus and I helped by collecting pine needles, which were used to cover the floor of the house and chink the gaps in the ceiling—a patchwork of thick, rough bark. Then, Kira hung a colorful God’s eye from one of the branches and Haley carved runes into another. With these finishing touches, the house was complete—all except for a name. Haley and Kira let Linus and me choose one. Having recently watched for the first time the Studio Ghibli classic, *Castle in the Sky*—in which the heroes are pursued by the military airship *Goliath*—we christened the house the *Goliath*.

After Haley and Kira graduated, Linus and I held onto the *Goliath* for a time before moving on to a new property. For a while, we lived with some friends in a little house surrounded by honeysuckle. There, we made and sold potions of grasses and mushrooms and moss and water and whatnot, and often played Witches, a game in which good witches and bad witches fought and captured each other for sport. But, due to the popularity of the game and the property owners’ willingness to welcome new residents, more and more children joined the

household, until eventually, the house became far too crowded, so Linus and I left to find a house of our own far away from the hustle and bustle of that central part of the Tunnels.

We discovered a cozy little spot further back in the woods, surrounded by trees and thick bushes. There, we invented a recipe for “leaf sugar” made from ground-up honeysuckle leaves. We sold the leaf sugar to our neighbors, two middle schoolers named Piper and Fiona. Piper and Fiona had a marvelous house. The ground was meticulously carpeted with moss; there were tables and chairs made of stumps and logs; there were little ornaments—pebbles, shells, nuts, and maple keys—decorating the house. Piper and Fiona were wonderful neighbors; they regularly purchased our leaf sugar as an ingredient for potions and often invited us over for “tea.” After Piper and Fiona graduated, Linus and I once again moved on to a new house.

Having drifted from place to place for a time, Linus and I hit the jackpot. One day, Linus discovered a massive supply of gold, the most coveted currency in the Tunnels. He’d found a decaying log, crumbling, not yet decomposed to the point of unusability, golden in color underneath the bark, which had concealed the wealth inside. After mining the vein dry, we took our loot and retired to a house in a quiet corner of the Tunnels. This state of affairs did not last long. Soon, we made an agreement with another household—one that was as wealthy as we—to join their residence, which was much larger than our own tiny house. We now were the wealthiest citizens of the Tunnels, and boasted the largest property. Drunk on these successes, I inwardly indulged the notion that nobody else in the history of the school had ever achieved what we had.

However, by this time, I was almost in middle school myself. Gradually, I played in the Tunnels less and less and played organized games of soccer, mat ball, and variations on tag more and more. All the while, the great saga of the Hiland Hall School Tunnels continued to unfold:

new games were created, new goods and services invented, new currencies devised to pay for them; newcomers arrived, old titans faded away—all as I slowly receded from that world and began to enter a new one. Before I knew it, I was nearing high school, walking in step with *Pomp and Circumstance*, outdoors due to the COVID-19 pandemic, not ten feet away from the entrance to the Tunnels, the storied depths of which were hidden by late-spring foliage.

Upon returning to the Tunnels last spring, after three years of high school, I found that the *Goliath* had collapsed into a decaying pile of branches; Piper and Fiona's lavish house was unused and unkempt; my former stockpile of gold had been reduced to a heap of old, decomposing wood and dirt. There is very little sign of my once-glorious presence in those woods. Yet, the Tunnels are alive as ever with new houses, bustling shops, and exciting activity, just as they were when I made play there, just as they were—I realize now—before I ever arrived. The essence of my experiences in the Tunnels will never fade away, because it lives on in my memory, in the memories of all Hiland Hall School alumni, and in the daily doings of the children who build, explore, and play in the Tunnels of the Hiland Hall School.